



Contrasting Carceral Imprisonments in *The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn*

Within Foucault's depiction of the carceral, he states that punishments that come from perceived offences will be a portion of daily life and dealt out by the people within the carceral. Foucault's carceral depends on the concept of societal enforcements and observations to enforce what is assumed to be justice (Foucault 1413). Within *The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn*, both Huck and Jim are placed in similar but competing carceral systems. For Huckleberry Finn, his carceral system includes religious priority and exactitude, even if the social religious practices do not align with the actual religious practices outlined in the Bible. For Jim, his imposed carceral system comes from being a slave in America with continuous surveillance and expectation that he should never be free. These combined carceral systems of Huckleberry Finn and Jim help to illuminate how individuals interact with each other in *The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn* and eventually create their own carceral systems.

Huckleberry Finn's carceral surrounding himself is shown through the religious references that he makes throughout the excerpt. Huck first references this religious carceral when he mentions that "was something inside me that kept saying" in reference to his internal moral compass (Twain 1). Huck mentions that this internal compass is dictated by religion when he later reflects that his kind treatment of Jim is because he was not regularly at Sunday School. This connection to Sunday School is not something that Huck is told in the excerpt by another individual but is understood and felt intuitively by Huck. Huck tells himself that "if you'd a done [sunday school] they'd a learnt you there that people that acts as I'd been acting about that nigger goes to everlasting fire" (Twain 1). Here Huck is feeling that the kind ways he has treated Jim have been a religious and social misstep because of his surrounding carceral.

Foucault echoes this underlying feeling of Huck's internal carceral when he states, "This vast mechanism (referring to the carceral) establishes a slow, continuous, imperceptible gradation that makes it possible to pass naturally from disorder to offence" (Foucault 1413). While Huck initially feels that it may be wrong to turn Jim in or to be unkind to him, his internal carceral causes a slow gradation to make Huck feel that it is necessary for Jim to be turned in, and that he must "go and write to the nigger's owner" (Twain 1). Huck is now not looking on the moral and personal obligation he has to Jim, but Huck slowly turns from disorder to offense in feeling that he must align with the religious carceral around him that states slaves must belong to their owners and be treated unkindly.

This religious carceral is then shown again when Huck tries to pray about what to do with Jim. Huck states, "I was trying to make my mouth SAY I would do the right thing" implying that Huck knew through the religious carceral the correct way to interact with the people around him

and Jim, even in something as personal as his prayers. Foucault echoes this idea with his concept of “the norm”. When society dictates a certain course of action, regardless of if it is correct or not, it becomes “the norm” and the standard by which society must operate (Foucault 1417). It now becomes “one of the major functions of society” and “the judges of normality are everywhere” (Foucault 1418). Even in something as personal as prayer, Huck was being influenced on the right way to act and the right way to pray based off of the people around him. Huck knew by enforced norms the correct way to pray and the thing he was supposed to ask for, even if that violated the personal beliefs Huck had.

Jim’s carceral system is viewed in direct opposition to the carceral system that Huck is living in. Huck mentions in trying to figure out if he should turn Jim in that “Somehow I couldn’t seem to strike no places to harden me against him” showing that even though Huck was supposed to view and treat Jim poorly that Huck could not find a reason to harm Jim (Twain 1). Huck doubles up on this opinion of Jim when Huck remembers, “how good he always was”(Twain 1).

Through this indecision about what to do with Jim, it is clear that there is a second carceral system in play in *The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn*, even though the individuals in the story are unable to see the second carceral. While Huck is operating under the assumption that Jim must be a foolish and wicked man as a black slave because of Huck’s religious carceral, Jim is then placed in a racially-based carceral system. This separation, however, is difficult in a carceral system, as Foucault states, because the individuals in the carceral are rarely able to see that they are in a social prison of their own making. “The carceral network does not cast the unassimilable into the confused hell; there is no outside. It takes back with one hand what it seems to exclude with the other. It saves everything, including what it punishes” (Foucault 1415). While readers are able to see the carceral system of Huck through his words and actions, the carceral system placed on Jim is shown primarily through the actions and words of the other characters in the excerpt and is not visible to the other characters in the story.

This is first shown through Huck’s remark at the beginning of the excerpt that “he’d GOT to be a slave” referring to Jim (Twain 1). Jim’s escape from slavery was not only seen as a break from the woman who owned him but also a break away from social standards that had been put in place. Huck then describes Jim’s escape as “wicked and low-down and ornery” to further show the carceral that Jim has been placed in as a slave (Twain 1). Finally, when Huck decides to help Jim be free, Huck states that he would “steal Jim out of slavery again” implying that if Jim were to escape that it would be because of Huck and not because of Jim’s efforts to be free (Twain 1). While Huck is helping Jim to be free physically with those statements, Huck is then putting Jim farther into the system of carceral enforcement by showing that only those enforcing the punishments could help Jim to be freed. It was the society around Jim that dictated how Jim would be able to live his life and not himself.

Foucault mentions this clearly when explaining how the system of punishment would continue throughout the society. He states in regards to the enforcers of the carceral, “It might even be said that nothing really distinguishes them any more (regardless of their behavior) except

the singularly dangerous character of the delinquents” (Foucault 1417). This can be directly seen between Jim and Huck. While Jim and Huck are both often participating in the same activities in the excerpt, Huck is considered acceptable, regardless of his behavior, because he is in the accepted carceral system. Jim, however, has been labeled a “delinquent” and must be separated from the rest of societal carcerals and placed in his own. The prisoners of the first carceral system are now the enforcers of the second carceral. Through these actions, however, it is clear to see that Huck is as much a prisoner of his carceral as Jim is. Both are held to their individual expectations by society, and neither can escape their carceral enforcements without a good deal of pain.

In conclusion, the differing carceral imprisonments of Huck and Jim in *The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn* help to illuminate the interactions between the characters in the story and the plot dynamics that occur throughout. With Huckleberry Finn’s religious carceral, it is shown the danger of forcing internally-aligned moral compasses and enforcing social norms through religion. In Jim’s racial carceral, it is shown the danger of constant surveillance and the immobilizing effects that has on the individuals inside the carceral. While Huck and Jim both break free from their imposed carceral, with Huck throwing away the note with Jim’s location and Jim showing consistently that he is a decent person, both individuals are placed into a new carceral punishment of their own creation as the story progresses. By the end of the story, both Huck and Jim are forced out of society and run away. This shows the continued danger of going against the carceral systems. Foucault’s final statement states that “we must hear the distant roar of battle” showing the struggle that will come from breaking out of carceral imprisonments (Foucault 1421). While Huck and Finn now have the freedom they were hoping for, it will always come at the cost of their previous carceral systems and the people within.

Works Cited

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